

PyTorch Hardware in May 2026

As of **May 15, 2026**, PyTorch does not have one hardware story. It has four. The API surface has become more uniform, especially across the PyTorch 2.8 through 2.12 releases, but the engineering reality underneath is still sharply backend-specific. On **NVIDIA CUDA**, PyTorch's compiler stack, kernel ecosystem, distributed tooling, and profilers reinforce one another in the way you want if your goal is large-scale LLM and ViT training. On **AMD ROCm**, PyTorch has crossed the threshold from "possible" to "credible," especially on MI300X and MI325X, but the path of least pain still usually runs through AMD-curated containers and workload recipes rather than a totally unremarkable upstream install. On **Google TPU**, PyTorch/XLA continues to deliver real scale, but it still asks the team to think in XLA terms: lazy execution, recompilations, shape stability, host/device sync points, and PJRT. On **Apple Silicon**, PyTorch MPS is much better than it was even a year ago, particularly in operator coverage and startup overhead, but `torch.compile` on Metal is still not a backend a serious team should treat as equivalent to CUDA or even ROCm for production model development. ¹

The strategic answer is therefore not "pick one accelerator and use it everywhere." The better answer, for most teams building frontier-style transformer workloads, is to distinguish between **local developer hardware** and **cluster truth**. Apple Silicon is unusually strong for **local prototyping, debugging, and memory-heavy laptop inference**, because unified memory changes what "fits" on a desk machine. But if you want a single cluster standard for training and high-performance serving under PyTorch, CUDA is still the default answer. ROCm is now a real second option when memory density, AMD procurement, or ecosystem strategy matter enough to absorb extra operational complexity. TPU is a strong option when you are willing to accept the XLA model—not merely tolerate it—and especially when your organization is already Google Cloud-native. ²

The most important distinction running through this entire report is the one between **"running"** and **"performant."** All four backends can run meaningful PyTorch workloads. Only one of them—CUDA—currently gives you a broadly production-grade answer across `torch.compile`, third-party kernels, quantization, profilers, and distributed systems without major caveats. ROCm is closer than it has ever been. TPU is powerful but different. MPS is valuable, but its value proposition is local and tactile rather than datacenter-like. ³

Executive Decision Matrix

The matrix below is a synthesis of upstream PyTorch 2.8–2.12 release notes, vendor installation guidance, backend-specific compiler documentation, and current issue trackers. The ratings are intentionally practical. "Maturity" means "how often a senior engineer can stay inside normal PyTorch habits without being surprised." "Cost efficiency" includes software friction and team time, not just silicon list price. Apple scores high there only for **local workstations and local inference**, not because it competes with datacenter accelerators on throughput. TPU scores high there only when the workload shape matches the TPU/XLA model and the team is comfortable living inside Google's operational model. ⁴

Platform	Maturity	<code>torch.compile</code> Stability	Kernel Availability	Debugging Ease	Cost Efficiency
Nvidia CUDA	High	High	High	High	Medium
AMD ROCm	Medium	Medium	Medium	Medium	Medium
Google TPU	Medium	Medium	Medium	Medium	High
Apple Silicon MPS	Medium	Low	Low	Medium	High

If the question is “**what should be the default PyTorch cluster standard?**”, the answer is still **CUDA**. PyTorch 2.7 added Blackwell support, PyTorch 2.11 added an upstream FlashAttention-4 backend for FlexAttention on Hopper and Blackwell, and PyTorch 2.12 continued to expand CUDA-first compiler and graph features. Nsight Systems 2026.2 now even annotates optimized graphs generated by `torch.compile`, which is exactly the kind of tooling convergence that turns a compiler feature into a dependable production tool rather than a benchmark trick. ⁵

If the question is “**what is the most interesting alternative?**”, ROCm now deserves a serious seat at the table. PyTorch 2.8 added functional support for the new `gfx950` architecture on ROCm 7 with max-autotune coverage in TorchInductor and the Composable Kernel backend; ROCm documentation now treats Triton and CK as first-class optimization tools; and AMD’s current `primus` training images ship with a modern stack that includes PyTorch, Triton, FlashAttention 2.8.3, Transformer Engine 2.8, hipBLASLt, and RCCL. But AMD’s own docs still recommend Docker as the preferred installation path specifically to avoid environment issues, which tells you that ROCm’s software story is improving faster than its “boring install” story. ⁶

If the question is “**what wins on cloud economics when the workload is XLA-friendly?**”, TPU is still formidable. Google’s public pricing shows **TPU v5p at \$4.20 per chip-hour** in Iowa, **Trillium at \$2.70 per chip-hour**, and **Ironwood at \$12.00 per chip-hour** in the same region, while Google also claims that Trillium improved performance per dollar over v5p for dense LLMs and that eighth-generation TPU 8t improves training performance-per-dollar over Ironwood for large-scale training. The catch is that PyTorch on TPU still lives behind PyTorch/XLA and XLA-native constraints, rather than feeling like a normal accelerator backend in the way CUDA does. ⁷

If the question is “**what is the fairest answer for local prototyping?**”, Apple deserves more respect than datacenter-biased analyses usually give it. Apple’s current public Mac lineup relevant to this discussion is unusually strong on memory capacity: Mac Studio currently ships with **M4 Max or M3 Ultra**, M3 Ultra scales to **512GB unified memory**, and Apple explicitly positions it for extremely large local AI workloads; meanwhile the current MacBook Pro line includes **M5 Max** systems with up to **128GB unified memory**. PyTorch 2.12 also moved all MPS tensors to unified memory unconditionally, which narrows the conceptual gap between PyTorch MPS and frameworks like MLX that were designed around Apple’s shared-memory model from the start. What Apple still does not have is a production-grade PyTorch compiler stack equivalent to CUDA. ⁸

Deep Dive on the torch.compile Landscape

The right way to think about `torch.compile` in 2026 is not as one compiler, but as a **frontend contract** with multiple backend personalities. The frontend has become more capable. PyTorch 2.8 introduced structured control-flow operators such as `cond`, `while_loop`, `scan`, `associative_scan`, and `map`, specifically so models with nontrivial control flow could be expressed in a way compatible with `torch.compile` and `torch.export`. By early 2026, PyTorch’s own docs were also publishing explicit guidance on common graph breaks, dynamic-shape pitfalls, and compiler-safe control flow. That matters because the frontend story has clearly matured. The backend story, however, still determines whether those graphs become fast code, fragile code, or a support ticket. ⁹

On **CUDA**, `torch.compile` is no longer merely “TorchInductor plus Triton.” It is now a layered system with multiple codegen paths and backend choices. PyTorch 2.8 added CUTLASS backend support for both `torch.compile` and AOTInductor, and by April 2026 PyTorch was publicly showing state-of-the-art GEMM generation on **B200** using TorchInductor’s **CuTeDSL backend**. PyTorch 2.10 reduced kernel-launch overhead with combo-kernel fusion, PyTorch 2.12 added a new device-agnostic `torch.accelerator.Graph` API and expanded graph capture behavior, and Nsight Systems 2026.2 added direct visibility into optimized graphs generated by `torch.compile`. In other words, CUDA has the thing the other backends still lack: a virtuous loop connecting PyTorch graph capture, mature codegen targets, hardware-specific kernel innovation, and first-party profiling. ¹⁰

CUDA also benefits from the fact that upstream PyTorch still treats NVIDIA as the reference path for new compiler ideas. Blackwell support landed in **PyTorch 2.7**, and performance work through 2025 and 2026 kept arriving on NVIDIA hardware first: warp-specialization work in Triton, Hopper-focused FlashAttention and SSD fusion work, and Blackwell-oriented quantization paths like **MXFP8** and **NVFP4** integrated through TorchAO and related libraries. That does not mean CUDA is bug-free. PyTorch still documents common graph breaks, dynamic-shape issues, and evolving distributed APIs under compile. But the difference is qualitative: on CUDA, most `torch.compile` failures feel like edge cases around an otherwise strong default; on the other backends, compile itself is still often the unstable variable. ¹¹

On **ROCm**, the question in 2026 is no longer “does `torch.compile` work at all?” It does. The real question is whether it feels **native** or still feels like a well-maintained side path. The answer is: better than 2025, but not yet CUDA-like. PyTorch 2.8 explicitly called out ROCm 7 support for `gfx950`, including max-autotune templates for `matmul`, `addmm`, `conv2d`, `bmm`, and `_scaled_mm` through TorchInductor and the AOTInductor Composable Kernel backend. ROCm’s own compatibility docs describe advanced Triton integration through AOTriton for newer architectures, and AMD’s optimization docs now treat both **Triton** and **Composable Kernel** as standard tools rather than science projects. PyTorch 2.12 added ROCm expandable memory segments, rocSHMEM-based symmetric memory collectives, and FlexAttention pipelining with reported speedups on MI350X. This is all substantial progress. ¹²

But ROCm still shows its seams in the developer workflow. AMD’s official installation guide says the **recommended** setup is a prebuilt Docker image because it “avoids potential installation issues.” The newer `primus` workflow is explicitly positioned as replacing earlier ROCm training containers, and the shipped software stacks in those images are often near-upstream or custom git builds of PyTorch rather than the exact mainstream release a CUDA user would expect from `pip install torch`. Even on the Radeon/Ryzen side, AMD documents AOTriton with an environment variable named

`TORCH_ROCM_AOTRITON_ENABLE_EXPERIMENTAL=1`. The message is not that ROCm compile is fake. It is that the fastest, safest ROCm path is still the **vendor-curated path**, not the totally banal upstream one. For standardization decisions, that matters. It means ROCm is now strong enough for deliberate adoption, but still not default enough for accidental adoption. ¹³

On **TPU**, the compiler stack is the platform. That is both the strength and the burden. Public PyTorch/XLA docs still describe the default model as **LazyTensor tracing**, where execution is deferred until `torch_xla.sync()` or an equivalent synchronization point. PyTorch/XLA's own newer docs introduce an **experimental eager mode** plus compile API to make TPU usage feel more native, and they recommend `torch.compile(..., backend="openxla")` for inference because it reduces tracing overhead. PJRT is now the officially supported runtime, and TPU docs note that PyTorch 2.1+ uses PJRT by default across TPU versions. This is a better developer story than PyTorch/XLA had a year before. But it is still visibly a bridge, not a first-class in-tree device backend. ¹⁴

The public roadmap makes that explicit. The PyTorch/XLA repository's README now says that **TorchTPU** has been announced and will replace PyTorch/XLA once public, while an open RFC proposes "a more native experience on TPU" precisely because the current model still feels distinct from normal eager PyTorch. That is an unusually strong signal from maintainers. It says the current bridge is working, but the maintainers themselves do not consider it the final form. This is where the JAX comparison becomes unavoidable. On newer Google TPU surfaces, public docs are still more direct about **JAX**. The TPU7x product page says Ironwood is GKE-only, contact-your-account-team, and explicitly notes that JAX can be used; meanwhile the TPU software-version page for PyTorch and JAX still centers **v5p** and **v6e**, not TPU7x. So the answer to "is PyTorch-on-TPU as seamless as JAX?" is still no. It is more workable than in the past, but still less native, less uniform, and less obviously aligned to the latest TPU product surface. ¹⁵

PyTorch/XLA's performance caveats reinforce that conclusion. Its own docs warn that recompilation is expensive and will recur when shapes change; they separate **tracing time**, **compilation time**, and **execution time** as distinct costs; and they note that synchronous operations like printing, logging, checkpointing, or forcing a tensor value to the host block tracing and degrade performance. The TPU model is therefore not just "another backend under `torch.compile`." It is still an **XLA execution model** that you need to understand. When that model matches your workload—large static shapes, disciplined training loops, and operators that lower cleanly—it can be excellent. When it doesn't, the penalty is conceptual as much as computational. ¹⁶

On **Apple Silicon MPS**, the split between eager mode and graph compilation is sharper than marketing language would suggest. The good news is real. PyTorch 2.11 publicly called out **comprehensive operator expansion** on MPS, including new distributions and migrated ops. PyTorch 2.12 added **Metal-4 offline shader compilation** so Apple Silicon wheels no longer pay the same first-run runtime shader compilation cost, and the same release moved all MPS tensors to unified memory unconditionally. Those are meaningful improvements. They reduce startup friction, reduce the "MPS is always behind" narrative on operator support, and align PyTorch better with Apple's underlying memory architecture. ¹⁷

But the compile story is still not mature. PyTorch's own compile progress tracker for MPS stated that `torch.compile` support on MPS was an **early prototype** and that end-to-end acceleration attempts were likely to fail. User-facing issues in 2025 and 2026 documented Metal codegen failures in reduction-heavy kernels and even NaN regressions during training when `torch.compile` was enabled on MPS while eager execution converged normally. The MPS backend also still exposes knobs like

`PYTORCH_MPS_PREFER_METAL` for matmul path selection and `PYTORCH_ENABLE_MPS_FALLBACK` for CPU fallback on unsupported ops. Those are useful escape hatches, but they are also evidence that MPS has not converged on a single obvious fast path. The practical verdict is straightforward: **eager MPS is a real tool; compiled MPS is still an experiment.** ¹⁸

The high-level compiler conclusion is therefore simple. If your team wants to treat `torch.compile` as the default acceleration switch for serious model work, **CUDA is the only backend where that instinct is consistently rewarded.** ROCm is increasingly viable, but still conditional on version discipline and curated environment choices. TPU remains powerful but XLA-shaped. MPS is worth using, but mostly as a correctness and local-iteration backend rather than as a place to bet on compiled performance parity. ¹⁹

The FlashAttention Test

If you want one backend-agnostic way to test whether a PyTorch hardware stack is really ready for 2026-era transformer work, use **attention kernels**. Attention is where the software stack stops being abstract. The backend either has fused kernels, good memory scheduling, and clean graph lowering—or it does not. By that standard, the platforms are not close. CUDA is clearly first; ROCm is now seriously competitive for supported environments; TPU can be excellent but mostly through compiler-native routes rather than the standard third-party kernel ecosystem; and Apple MPS still does not have an upstream FlashAttention-class answer in native PyTorch. ²⁰

On **CUDA**, fast attention is no longer an external add-on story only. It is increasingly an upstream PyTorch story. PyTorch 2.11 introduced a **FlashAttention-4 backend** for FlexAttention on **Hopper and Blackwell**, with PyTorch reporting **1.2× to 3.2×** gains over the previous Triton implementation on compute-bound workloads. That matters for two reasons. First, it means PyTorch is not merely relying on the external `flash-attn` package to solve the most important transformer kernel family. Second, it means the attention story is now tied directly into the compile stack: PyTorch can JIT-instantiate and specialize newer attention backends from Python-level definitions. On top of that, Hopper’s hardware Transformer Engine and FP8 support remain the most mature low-precision training surface in the field, while Blackwell extends the quantization frontier further with MXFP8 and NVFP4 workflows that PyTorch and TorchAO are already exposing in public examples. ²¹

The CUDA attention path also benefits from the broader kernel ecosystem around Triton. PyTorch’s own performance work on warp specialization and fused SSD/Mamba-2 kernels has landed specifically on A100, H100, and newer NVIDIA parts. That does not mean every transformer variant is solved. But it does mean the ecosystem that matters for modern attention innovation—Triton, FlexAttention, CUTLASS, CuTeDSL, TorchAO, flash-attn-style kernels, profiling, and upstream compiler work—is still centered on NVIDIA first. If your roadmap includes unusual attention variants, custom score modifications, or aggressive low-precision serving, this concentration of tooling is a very large strategic advantage. ²²

On **ROCm**, the attention picture has changed dramatically from the “CUDA-only reality” of earlier years. AMD’s own ROCm docs now state that **FlashAttention 2** on AMD GPUs supports **two backend implementations: Composable Kernel**, which is the default backend, and **OpenAI Triton**, which is an alternative path. AMD also ships training containers that already include **FlashAttention 2.8.3** and **Transformer Engine 2.8** for MI300X and MI325X-class workflows. In PyTorch 2.12, AMD also landed a FlexAttention pipelining optimization on ROCm that reported **5–26%** speedups across several attention

patterns on MI350X. This is no longer a backend where “fast attention” means “good luck.” It is a backend where fast attention is real, documented, and in active optimization. ²³

The caveat is the important one: on ROCm, fast attention is often **plug-and-play inside the supported container**, not necessarily in arbitrary user environments. That distinction matters if you are standardizing a team. If everyone lives in ROCm-tested images, FlashAttention on MI300X and MI325X is a credible part of the native workflow. If half the team lives in ad hoc pip environments, custom wheels, or drifting Python stacks, a lot of ROCm’s advertised smoothness disappears quickly. The practical translation is that ROCm passes the FlashAttention test only if you also accept ROCm’s preference for **curated environments and version discipline**. CUDA still passes it more casually. ²⁴

On **TPU**, there is no direct equivalent to “install the flash-attn wheel and go.” Efficient attention on TPU is increasingly possible, but it tends to arrive through **XLA lowering, compiler fusion**, or **Pallas**, not through the same ecosystem logic that dominates NVIDIA. PyTorch/XLA’s docs explicitly position **Pallas** as the TPU answer to the custom-kernel culture created by Triton and kernels like FlashAttention and PagedAttention. That is promising, and it matters for long-term parity. But it is not the same thing as having a deep, standard, easy-to-adopt third-party kernel market for PyTorch on TPU today. The closest fair statement is that TPU has the ingredients for high-performance attention, but still not the same “drop-in kernel abundance” that CUDA users now treat as normal. ²⁵

TPU’s quantization story shows the same pattern. PyTorch/XLA now documents **quantized operations** for XLA devices, including APIs for blockwise **int4**-style quantized matrix multiplication, and states that these ops are compatible with `torch.compile(backend="openxla")`. But the docs also label the feature experimental. That is the recurring TPU theme in 2026: powerful primitives exist, but the surrounding developer story still has a bridge quality to it. If your team is deep enough in XLA and willing to use the TPU-native paths, that may be fine. If you are expecting CUDA-style ecosystem breadth around low-bit inference and serving, it is not the same experience. ²⁶

On **Apple MPS**, the answer is much harsher. PyTorch’s own MPS compile tracker still listed **FlexAttention on MPS** as stretch performance work and explicitly called out decisions still pending around decomposing `_scaled_dot_product_attention_math_for_mps`. That means native upstream PyTorch on MPS still does **not** offer a mature FlashAttention-2 or FlashAttention-3 class backend. There is an MPS-specific SDPA math path, but that is not the same thing as having a specialized fused attention kernel ecosystem of the kind modern LLM work expects. So if the question is “does Apple PyTorch have a native FlashAttention answer now?” the honest answer is still no. ²⁷

This is exactly why **MLX** needs to be part of the Apple discussion even in a PyTorch report. MLX is designed around Apple Silicon’s unified memory; its arrays live in shared memory and can run across supported devices without explicit transfers; and **MLX-LM** ships straightforward flows for quantizing models, loading ready-made 4-bit checkpoints from Hugging Face, and doing distributed inference and fine-tuning with `mx.distributed`. By contrast, TorchAO’s Apple-facing docs currently spotlight experimental low-bit kernels that run on **ARM CPUs on Apple Silicon Macs**, not on the MPS GPU as a first-class quantized backend. So for local Apple inference, particularly low-bit LLM inference, MLX is currently the better-tuned Apple-native answer. But that comes with a strategic cost: **MLX is not native PyTorch portability**. Code you prototype in MLX does not lift cleanly to CUDA or ROCm clusters the way idiomatic PyTorch does. ²⁸

The FlashAttention test therefore gives a very clean result. **CUDA** passes decisively. **ROCm** passes with environmental discipline. **TPU** passes only if your notion of “native kernel support” includes XLA/Pallas compilation rather than the usual PyTorch extension ecosystem. **MPS** does not pass in native PyTorch; Apple’s strongest local low-bit answer remains adjacent to PyTorch, not inside it. ²⁹

Local and Cloud Delineation

The hardest strategic mistake teams make in 2026 is trying to turn the phrase “**MacBook to cluster**” into a claim of literal backend symmetry. There is no literal symmetry. What exists instead is a portability ladder. At the top of that ladder is **plain eager PyTorch with standard operators and common module patterns**. That code moves reasonably well between MPS, CUDA, and ROCm. At the bottom of that ladder are **backend-specific kernels, backend-specific compile assumptions, and framework-specific quantization stacks**. That code does not move cleanly at all. The key to a healthy workflow is to keep correctness portable and let performance be backend-specific. ³⁰

For a team prototyping on Macs, Apple Silicon is genuinely useful in ways that datacenter-only analyses often underweight. PyTorch MPS is built into the normal Apple Silicon wheel path, MLX installs with a simple `pip install mlx` on Apple Silicon with native Python and macOS 14+, and Apple’s current machines are unusually memory-dense for personal systems. Public Apple specs show **M4 Max** systems with up to **128GB unified memory** and up to **546GB/s** memory bandwidth, **M5 Max** systems with up to **128GB unified memory** and up to **614GB/s** memory bandwidth, and **M3 Ultra** systems with up to **512GB unified memory** and roughly **819GB/s** memory bandwidth. Apple also publicly claims that M3 Ultra can run LLMs with **over 600 billion parameters directly on device**. Whether or not you accept Apple’s exact model claim, the important engineering point is undeniable: Apple gives a developer access to **far more directly usable memory on a desk or in a backpack** than discrete consumer GPUs typically do. ³¹

That unified-memory story matters most for **local inference**. A 70B model in 4-bit form is on the order of **35GB of raw weight storage** before accounting for scales, metadata, runtime buffers, and KV cache. In practice that means a 64GB or 128GB Apple machine can host model sizes that are awkward on many discrete GPUs without tensor parallelism or offload. PyTorch 2.12’s move to unified memory for all MPS tensors makes the PyTorch mental model on Apple more consistent with this underlying hardware, and MLX was already designed around the same principle: arrays live in shared memory, so you are not manually staging host copies into a separate VRAM pool. That is a major usability advantage for local experimentation. It is also precisely why Apple deserves a high local cost-efficiency score. ³²

But unified memory should not be romanticized into datacenter equivalence. Apple’s best local systems still run at **hundreds of GB/s** of memory bandwidth, not **multi-terabyte-per-second HBM** levels. Google’s TPU v5p exposes **95 GiB HBM** and **2575 GiB/s** HBM bandwidth per chip; Trillium exposes **32 GB HBM** and **1638 GiB/s**; TPU7x exposes **192 GiB HBM** and **7380 GiB/s**; AMD MI300X exposes **192 GB HBM3** and **5.3 TB/s**; and AMD MI325X pushes to **256 GB HBM3E** and **6.0 TB/s** with much higher FP8 throughput than MI300X. Apple’s value is therefore not that it beats datacenter accelerators. Its value is that it lets a single developer manipulate very large model states locally **without the CPU-to-VRAM staging model** that discrete accelerators still impose. For local work, that is not a small detail. It changes what “convenient” means. ³³

The interconnect story clarifies where each platform belongs. **NVIDIA NVLink** is still the gold standard for PyTorch scale-up. On Hopper, NVIDIA advertises **900 GB/s bidirectional NVLink** per GPU; on Blackwell, NVIDIA’s NVLink switch fabric enables a **72-GPU NVLink domain** with **130TB/s** of GPU bandwidth and **1.8**

TB/s interconnect support beyond a single server; and Rubin pushes the public roadmap even further, with **3.6 TB/s bidirectional bandwidth per GPU** in Vera Rubin NVL72. **AMD Infinity Fabric** is now a serious node-scale fabric—MI300X uses **eight Infinity Fabric links** at **128 GB/s** and forms a fully connected 8-GPU system—but the surrounding PyTorch software ecosystem still does not exploit it as effortlessly as PyTorch exploits NVLink through NCCL and the CUDA-first toolchain. **Google ICI** is deeply integrated into TPU execution itself: v5p offers **1200 GB/s** bidirectional ICI bandwidth per chip and a 3D torus topology, while v6e uses **800 GB/s** and a 2D torus. **Apple's internal fabric** is something else entirely: M3 Ultra's UltraFusion gives **over 2.5TB/s** of die-to-die interprocessor bandwidth inside one workstation package, while external expansion is still basically Thunderbolt 5 territory at **up to 120 Gb/s** rather than a datacenter rack fabric. Apple's internal fabric is excellent for a box. It is not a cluster interconnect. 34

This is why the **MacBook to cluster** workflow should be understood as **API portability, not performance portability**. If you prototype a ViT or LLM block in plain PyTorch on MPS, keep device logic abstract, avoid backend-specific dtype assumptions, and validate with standard SDPA and `nn.Module` code, then moving to CUDA or ROCm is usually straightforward. Moving to TPU is less straightforward because the TPU execution model itself differs: PyTorch/XLA's own migration guide explains that TPUs default to a lazy execution model, rely on different distributed utilities and SPMD patterns, and recompile when graph structure or shapes change. So Apple-to-CUDA and Apple-to-ROCm is mostly a software-stack transition; Apple-to-TPU is a software-stack transition **and** an execution-model transition. 35

Installation friction reinforces the same separation. On **CUDA**, the official PyTorch guidance is still the most boring: pick the right CUDA version in the install selector and `pip install torch`. On **ROCm**, pip wheels exist, but AMD's official docs still recommend the **prebuilt Docker image** to avoid environment issues, and their flagship training workflow is increasingly expressed through the `rocm/primus` containers. On **TPU**, the quickstart means provisioning a TPU VM, choosing the right runtime version, installing `torch_xla[tpu]`, and often setting `PJRT_DEVICE=TPU`; on Ironwood, the public product page adds more operational constraints by requiring **GKE** and account-team access. On **Apple**, both PyTorch MPS and MLX are simple local installs. That is not a superficial quality-of-life point. It tells you which platform can support casual contributors and which platform demands platform engineering discipline. 36

The profiling and debugging stack is just as uneven. **Nsight Systems** in 2026 is a mature performance workstation: it has CLI support, cluster/Kubernetes surfaces, and direct PyTorch-specific improvements such as annotation of optimized graphs generated by `torch.compile`. **ROCm** has made real strides here too: ROCm 7.1 release notes highlight validated support for PyTorch and JAX in ROCm Systems Profiler, dynamic process attachment, better TUI analysis, and `rocprofv3` improvements. **TPU** offers **XProf** and TensorBoard-based profiling for PyTorch/XLA workloads, and Google has explicit documentation for capturing PyTorch XLA traces. **MPS** offers `torch.mps.profiler.start()` and OS Signpost tracing that can be viewed in Xcode Instruments. That is useful, but it is not yet a peer of Nsight in the day-to-day workflow of squeezing out LLM performance. The gap is not that Apple and TPU have no tools. It is that CUDA's tools are still much closer to the way PyTorch performance engineers actually work. 37

The fair bottom line for local versus cloud, then, is this. **Apple is the best local-human backend**, not because it wins benchmarks, but because it gives a developer massive directly usable memory and low-friction installs in a portable machine. **CUDA is the best cluster-human backend**, because it lets the same team scale that work without learning a new compiler religion. **ROCm is the strongest alternative cluster bet** if you consciously want AMD's memory-heavy nodes and can centralize platform ownership. **TPU is the**

specialized cloud bet when you accept XLA as part of the programming model rather than as a hidden implementation detail. ³⁸

Critical Failure Modes

The most useful way to describe failure modes in 2026 is not by asking which backend crashes. All of them can crash. The useful question is **what kind of surprise** each backend tends to generate.

On **CUDA**, the common surprises are mostly compiler-surface surprises rather than platform surprises. PyTorch still documents common graph breaks, dynamic-shape guard problems, and the need to rewrite certain Python control-flow patterns into structured operators if you want stable compilation. PyTorch 2.12 also changed behavior in distributed compile paths, explicitly steering users away from older `torch.distributed.nn.functional` collectives under `torch.compile`. But these are the kinds of issues teams can usually localize and fix without doubting the platform. They feel like ordinary compiler work. In practice, CUDA's biggest failures are usually around **user code patterns, extension ABI drift, or cluster orchestration**, not around "is this backend strategically real?" ³⁹

On **ROCm**, the dominant breakage mode is usually environmental. AMD's own docs recommend Docker specifically to avoid installation issues; leading training workflows are packaged into `primus` images that pin PyTorch, Triton, FlashAttention, Transformer Engine, and RCCL together; and some ROCm compile paths still expose experimental toggles or architecture-specific behaviors. In other words, ROCm often breaks first at the **toolchain boundary**. A model that runs correctly may still underperform because it fell off the intended kernel path. A developer who uses a slightly different wheel set may lose the clean "supported stack" that AMD documents. This is the backend where version skew and container drift are still disproportionately expensive. ⁴⁰

On **TPU**, the main thing that breaks is the assumption that eager PyTorch intuition is enough. PyTorch/XLA's own docs warn about expensive recompilations when shapes change, explain that tracing time and execution time are different, and emphasize that synchronous host-side operations such as printing tensors, logging values, checkpointing, or calling back into Python can block tracing and degrade performance. Public docs also show that the project is still in transition—PyTorch/XLA is not the endpoint, and a future TorchTPU path is planned. So the TPU failure mode is usually not "the TPU is broken." It is "the code is semantically valid PyTorch, but it is a bad PyTorch/XLA program." That difference is why TPU can be wonderful for some teams and exhausting for others. ⁴¹

On **Apple MPS**, the failure modes are the most concrete. Unsupported operators can still push users toward `PYTORCH_ENABLE_MPS_FALLBACK=1`, which turns an MPS model into a mixed CPU/MPS execution path that may be far slower and, in some cases, semantically awkward. PyTorch's MPS operator coverage tracker is still open and explicitly says the support matrix is not exhaustive. User-visible issues have included missing distributed `c10d` support on MPS with broken fallback semantics, hard limitations such as unsupported large-channel conv cases in earlier reports, and, most importantly, `torch.compile`-specific failures ranging from invalid generated Metal code for reduction-heavy kernels to NaN regressions during training. If CUDA mostly fails like a compiler and TPU mostly fails like XLA, MPS still sometimes fails like a **prototype backend**. ⁴²

From a team-operations perspective, that means the backend-specific “what breaks?” list is also a staffing guide. CUDA needs strong PyTorch and distributed systems engineers. ROCm needs those same engineers **plus** someone who wants to own containers, CI matrices, and AMD-specific performance validation. TPU needs model engineers who are willing to think in XLA terms and accept that shape discipline, host sync discipline, and compile behavior are part of daily life. Apple MPS needs a team that treats it as a **developer acceleration surface**, not as the final place where performance truth will be established. 43

Final Recommendation

For **research teams**, the strongest standardization pattern in May 2026 is **Apple laptops for local work, CUDA for cluster truth, and plain PyTorch as the shared programming model**. That recommendation is not anti-AMD and not anti-TPU. It is a recognition that most research teams need two things at once: a flexible local environment with lots of memory and low friction, and a cluster environment where every major PyTorch optimization path is available without qualification. Apple gives you the first unusually well: high-memory local systems, unified memory, good local inference ergonomics, and simple installation. CUDA gives you the second: the most mature `torch.compile` backend, the deepest fast-attention ecosystem, the most complete quantization path, the least surprising profiler stack, and the cleanest path from a single-GPU prototype to distributed training and serving. If your researchers want to use MLX locally for low-bit Apple-native LLM inference, that is perfectly compatible with this model, as long as the team understands that MLX is a **local specialization**, not the cluster standard. 44

For **production teams**, the default answer should still be **NVIDIA CUDA unless you have a deliberate reason not to**. The reason is not just benchmarks. It is the convergence of upstream support around CUDA. Blackwell support landed in 2.7. FlashAttention-4 landed upstream on Hopper and Blackwell in 2.11. CuTeDSL and other advanced GEMM paths are already showing B200-centric performance work in 2026. Nsight has direct awareness of compiled PyTorch graphs. This is the platform where PyTorch’s most ambitious features become operational reality fastest. If the production team will be judged on delivery confidence more than on squeezing every hardware-dollar, CUDA remains the lowest-risk standard. 45

ROCm should be chosen when its advantages are strategic enough to justify first-class ownership. The strongest reasons are memory-heavy workloads on MI300X/MI325X-class nodes, organizational preference for AMD procurement, or a deliberate effort to avoid single-vendor dependence in the datacenter. In those cases, ROCm is now strong enough that the choice is technically serious, not symbolic. But it is a choice that should come with platform discipline from day one: curated containers, explicit ROCm versions, benchmark-based regression testing, and acceptance that the best-documented path may live in AMD’s images before it lands as a perfectly ordinary upstream PyTorch experience. If a company chooses ROCm expecting all the economics of AMD with all the boredom of CUDA, it will be disappointed. If it chooses ROCm expecting a real but more hands-on alternative, it can succeed. 46

TPU should be treated as the right answer for a narrower but still important set of organizations: teams that are already strongly aligned with **Google Cloud**, are comfortable with **XLA/PJRT and compiler-shaped workflows**, and can benefit from TPU economics and scale characteristics for workloads that compile well. The public pricing and performance-per-dollar signals around Trillium and the announced eighth-generation TPU 8t/8i line are meaningful. But the software story still says “XLA-first” more than “just another PyTorch backend,” and the newest TPU surfaces are still more visibly documented for JAX than for PyTorch. If your team wants PyTorch because it wants **eager-first ergonomics and backend invisibility**, TPU is still

not the most natural fit. If your team wants **large-scale compiler-driven execution** and is willing to adopt the TPU worldview, it can be an excellent fit. ⁴⁷

Apple Silicon should absolutely be standardized for the local workflow if your team values mobility, on-device inference, quiet local experimentation, and the ability to fit surprisingly large models on developer machines. But it should not be mistaken for a PyTorch cluster standard. Native PyTorch MPS is now good enough to be worth using every day for local development, validation, and smaller training loops. It is not yet good enough that you should use MPS compile behavior as a proxy for CUDA compile behavior. And if your Apple roadmap depends heavily on low-bit LLM inference, be honest about the current split: **MLX is the stronger Apple-native low-bit inference stack**, while **PyTorch MPS remains the stronger portability story**. That is not a contradiction. It is the present state of the ecosystem. ⁴⁸

The clearest single recommendation, then, is this: **standardize on PyTorch as the programming model, CUDA as the cluster reference backend, and Apple Silicon as the local prototyping edge**. Add ROCm only as an intentional second cluster target with dedicated ownership. Add TPU only when you are intentionally choosing the XLA/Google Cloud model rather than trying to hide it. That combination is the closest thing to a durable, engineering-realistic answer for a team building LLMs and ViTs across the full lifecycle in May 2026. ⁴⁹

¹ ⁶ ⁹ ¹⁰ ¹² PyTorch 2.8 Release Blog

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⁷ ⁴⁷ TPU Pricing | Google Cloud

<https://cloud.google.com/tpu/pricing>

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¹³ ²⁴ ⁴⁰ ⁴⁶ PyTorch on ROCm installation

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¹⁴ Eager Mode + Compile API

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¹⁵ Enabling PyTorch on XLA Devices (e.g. Google TPU)

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